

'I want to be a world champion some day'

"... and I hope I can be on the podium at the 2028 Olympics," says Anmol Kharb after **leading India** to its maiden Badminton Asia Team Championships title.

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Anmol Kharb needed a few days to handle the overwhelming adulation that followed her win in the final singles tie against Thailand at the Asian Badminton Team Championships. After all, it was her victory that sealed India's historic gold medal.

"After I won my match, I didn't touch my phone for two hours after the final. It was just blowing up," the 17-year-old tells *Sportstar*. "There were just so many notifications; I got so many follow requests on *Instagram*, DMs (direct messages), and story tags. I tried my best to respond to as many of them as I could. There are just so many people who want to meet you that I've not had time to train properly. I won't mind when things get a little calm once again. I don't know how those big star players manage to do it," she says.

Anmol is close to becoming a star player herself, and that has its own perks.

"One of my friends is a very big fan of

(Indian men's doubles player) Chirag (Shetty). Actually, before I joined the Indian team, she told me to get his autograph. And after we won the gold medal, I got a message from Chirag bhaiyya directly. So, I took the chance to ask him if he could record an audio message for her. He said, 'Of course. You have made our country proud, so this is the least I can do'. Then he recorded a personal message for her. It felt really good that such a big star was doing that for me. And my friend was also very happy," says Anmol.

"They are saying now we need you to give us your autograph. They are only teasing, but it's a little funny because I've never seen myself like one of those stars," she adds.

A few years ago, not many would have. Not even Anmol's father, Devender Kharb, who set her career in motion when he and a group of his neighbours got together to build a cement badminton court at their residential complex in Sector 16 in Faridabad.

"I just did that because we thought it would be a nice recreational activity," says Devender, who



travelled to Selangor, Malaysia, where he watched from the stands as his daughter scripted history over the course of the week.

In the final against Thailand, India was tied 2-2 before Anmol secured a decisive victory by defeating world number 45, Pornpicha Choeikeewong, with a score of 21-14, 21-9. National coach Pullela Gopi Chand enthusiastically gave her a high five, and her teammates lifted her amid cheers. This marked Anmol's third consecutive win against higher-ranked opponents at

